digs that were family homes in their own way, I got my own place. Ryan Giggs had already moved into a house in Worsley, North Manchester, and he told me there was another three-storey townhouse nearby that was coming up for sale. It was perfect. Worsley was a nice, quiet village, the house was brand new and barely ten minutes from the training ground: now I'd never have an excuse for arriving late for work.

I'd grown up in a suburban semi on the outskirts of London, in a house just about big enough for the five of us. Now here I was, collecting the keys to a proper bachelor pad and making it my own: a den with a pool table, a leather suite in the front room, a Bang & Olufsen television and music system, and a great big fireplace. The top floor was just one huge room, my bedroom. I had wardrobes made for it and, when the carpenters put them in, I got them to build a cabinet at the bottom of my bed. You pressed a button and the television would come up out of it. When we first started going out together, Victoria used to rip me apart about that. And I had my mate, Giggsy, living next door, as well: what more could any boy ask for?

Even then, Ryan was a legend at United. He was only a year older than me and we'd played in the same Youth Cup winning side, but it seemed as if he was already a star when I got to Manchester. Giggsy was a first-team regular by the time he was eighteen. He was a hero to the younger lads and he was also great to work alongside. Once I moved in next door, I got to know him really well. And that meant getting to know all his mates at the same time: the so-called Worsley Crew. We'd all meet up at the local pub, the Barton Arms, for lunch. I felt like I was keeping Manchester's coolest company.

Giggsy and I have stayed close ever since. He's still someone who can win a game on his own, still a player every opposing defender will tell you they hate playing against. Think back to the 'New George Best' tag he grew up with. Giggsy's had his ups and downs at United like any other player but, over the past twelve years, he's had the ability and strength of character to live up to all the expectations people had of him. I hope Wales make it to Portugal for the European Championships in 2004: it would be great to see Giggsy on that international stage. Whatever happens, by the time he packs it in—and there's not much chance of that for a long while—he'll go down as one of United's all-time greats.

I suppose lots of young lads in my situation would have been living on take-out food and looking for a phone number for a good cleaner. I've always been what you might call domesticated, though. Even when I was a boy,